

Overview & Purpose

Background information on why this research is needed

Trial Clerks are responsible for recording everything that happens during a trial session. Currently, they take handwritten notes during the proceeding. Later, they must enter all of these notes, along with any exhibits into Dawson. The purpose of this research is to learn more about their process, pain points, and identify potential solutions that would make this process faster for trial clerks.

Research Methods

How we will approach our research to gather the information we need

- Focus Group scheduled remotely via zoom

Engagement Groups

A list of people we will speak with to learn more about their experiences

In order to gather diverse perspectives from people that utilize DAWSON, we met with 5 court personnel, Product Owner, and Product Specialist

Interview Guide

Questions we will reference to guide our conversations with users

Thank you for your time today, we really appreciate it. Intros. The topic today is minute sheets. Your feedback will help improve the minute sheet workflow from entering data to getting that data into Dawson. Since we have an hour and lots to cover, we'd like to stay on topic and avoid going down rabbit holes. We're going to screenshare and go through each of the minute sheets field by field, with our questions. We'll ask for your desired changes after specific sections are covered. After the forms are covered, we'll talk about the minute sheet data and Dawson. If we don't get through everything today, we may need to set up another meeting so we can capture all of your feedback. Are there any questions or concerns? Is it ok if we record this meeting for our notes later?

(RECORD and TURN ON TRANSCRIPTION OPTION)

Would it be okay if I record this meeting for note-taking purposes?

Do you have any questions before we get started?

Open pdf of blank trial minute sheet in browser:

1. Auto populate: docket nos, title of case, date called, place, judge, trial clerk, reporter, page numbers - any other data points won't change and can be auto populated? Confirm that all of these should be editable.
2. Dropdown under Date Recalled - Trial, Hearing, Partial Trial, Further Trial, Further Hearing
 - a. Should we keep these options as is?
 - b. Why are Hearing/Further Hearing part of the list since there's a separate minute sheet for those?
 - c. Are dates the only input for these fields?
 - d. Are dates entered as the trial goes on or entered at the end of the session?
3. Case Not Called or Recalled - what type of answer goes in this field?
4. Transcript Ordered - what type of answer goes in this field?
5. Vertical rectangular section on the right side - is this relevant and being used?
 - a. There are no clickable fields so are these being handwritten?
6. Dropdown under Case Not Called - Judge, Special Trial Judge
 - a. Assumption is the latter presides over special sessions - why the separate title?
7. Counsels - we know who they are ahead of time - who is listed in these fields?
8. **What changes/improvements are needed in this section?**
9. Actions and Filings - how is this section filled out? Are these related to another section, like exhibits?
10. Dropdown under Submitted - Simultaneous Briefs, Memoranda of Law, Memorandum Briefs
 - a. Should we keep these options as is?
 - b. Why are Bench Opinion and Seriatim Brief separated out from the dropdown list?
 - c. What type of answers go in these fields?
11. Opening and Answering - what do these mean?
12. Why is there one Reply field but two of the above (#10)?
13. Time Consumed in Trial - is this manually calculated?
14. Trial Clerk and Reporter fields - are these tied to any of the fields in this section?
15. **What changes/improvements are needed in this section?**
16. Witnesses - do we know who they are ahead of time?
17. Exhibits - confirm each exhibit is grouped with its pertaining witnesses in the order they appeared
 - a. Which source(s) are the exhibits coming from?
 - b. How are they being entered (from memory, template text, trial notes, etc.)?
 - c. Statuses - not offered, withdrawn, admitted, not admitted, n/a, ?
 - d. Proposed exhibits - brought up last week - do we need to add to the list of status?
18. **What changes/improvements are needed in this section?**

Open pdf of calendar call minute sheet:

1. Top part should be the same as trial minute sheet (Auto populate: docket nos, title of case, date called, place, judge, trial clerk, reporter)?
2. Dropdown under Counsel for Respondent - Jurisdiction Retained-Stip. Dec. Due, Juris. Retained, Stip. Dec. Due
 - a. Should we keep these options as is?
 - b. What type of answer goes in this field?
3. Dropdown under above - Joint Status Report Due, Resp. Status Report Due, Petr. Status Report Due, Petr. & Resp. Status Reports Due
 - a. Should we keep these options as is?
 - b. What type of answer goes in this field?
4. **What changes/improvements are needed in this section?**
5. Date section - is this supposed to be organized as rows?
 - a. Is this a single selection from the 6 options?
 - b. Could Pretrial Conference Held be moved to another section? (from the last meeting)
 - c. First row dropdown - Jt. Oral Mot. for Gen. Cont., Petr. Mot. for Gen. Cont., Resp. Mot. for Gen. Cont., etc. (10 in list)
 - i. Should we keep these options as is?
 - ii. What type of answer goes in this field?
 - d. See order, CAV, granted, denied - one selection per row? And it would be a date in the field?
6. **What changes/improvements are needed in this section?**
7. FILINGS, OTHER ACTIONS AND ORAL MOTIONS
 - a. How is this section filled out?
 - b. Would a list of common actions/filings/oral motions to select from be helpful?
 - c. Statuses for each in the list (including granted/denied for oral motions)
8. **What changes/improvements are needed in this section?**
9. Are these sheets entered into the docket record? If so, which cases (all that were called?)

Follow up questions:

- Do we want these to be multi docketed for consolidated cases?
- Will we need printable blank forms?
- Exhibits - they're already in the docket record - is there a need to have them on the minute sheet too?
- What other types of data need to be captured when thinking of this as a trial session history?
- What other changes or improvements do you want to see on these forms that haven't been brought up?

Outcomes

After conducting the focus group, the transcripts and recording were reviewed and the content synthesized for analysis. This led to the creation of a prototype, which is currently in production.